

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK - CAPITOL THEATRE

Mr Thomas Rees began showing Theatregraph Pictures each Friday night in Petersburg in 1912 at the Town Hall. He married Ruby Reid in 1915 at Broken Hill. Ruby was employed in Petersburg at the Junction Hotel when Mr Rees came to the town in 1909. In 1917 Tom purchased the building on lot 11 Main Street and used the premises to show pictures.

Tired of waiting for the council to erect a new town hall, Thomas Rees and his brother Herbert Watkin Rees applied to the council for permission to erect a theatre on the block in November 1925. The old building was demolished, and the building of the Capitol Theatre began. The contractor for the theatre was Messrs Silver and Ollrich of Rosewater. Mr Lowe of Port Adelaide was responsible for the lighting and Mr Matthews of Adelaide the decorations.

The theatre was completed by April and was used by the Catholic Church on May 3rd for a people's reception and entertainment evening at 8 pm to honour the visit of the prelates (Archbishops and Bishops) of the Roman Catholic Hierarchy.

It was officially opened on Saturday 15th May 1926.

On Saturday evening the new Capitol Picture Theatre was opened by Mr. A. R. G. Hawke, M.P. Mr. Hawke said the building was what the town had required for years. It could now boast of a hall second to none in the State. He wished the proprietors every success, and had great pleasure in declaring the theatre open. The building, which is situated in Main-street west, is 50 ft. wide and 140 ft. long. The body of the hall is 50 ft. by 100 ft. The dress circle will seat 220, the stalls 600, and the pit 200, a total of 1,020. It was designed primarily as a picture hall, but was constructed so that theatrical parties can use it also. Special attention has been paid to the ventilation, the ceiling being of lattice work, and 12 electric fans having been installed. All the woodwork is polished blackwood. At the main entrance on either side are two shops. The vestibule is lined with tiles, and the wall is tiled to a height of 12 ft. On the ground floor are the ticket offices, manager's office, and ladies' retiring rooms. The stage is 50 ft. long and 25 ft. wide, with two dressing rooms at the back. The proprietors are Messrs. H. W. and Thos. Rees. The contractors were Messrs. Silver and Ollrich, of Rosewater. Mr. Matthews, of Adelaide, was responsible for the decorations, and Mr. Lowe, of Port Adelaide, had charge of the lighting.

The Chronicle
Saturday 22 May 1926

CAPITOL THEATRE

PETERBOROUGH.

Saturday Next, July 2nd.

Corrine Griffiths

—IN—
"SYNCOPIATING
SUE"

William Haines and
Claire Windsor in

"A LITTLE
JOURNEY"

Monday Next, July 4th.

WALLACE BEERY &
RAYMOND HATTON

—IN—
"WE'RE IN THE
NAVY NOW"

Wednesday Next, July 6th

IRENE RICH in

"SILKEN
SHACKLES"

—IN—
NORMA SHEARER

"THE TRAIL OF
THE LAW"

Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 1 July 1927

Capitol Theatre

TWO BIG NIGHTS

SATURDAY AND MONDAY

Every Child paying for admission
will receive a Book, "The Life Story
of Shirley Temple."

SHIRLEY TEMPLE

In this, her most touching pic-
ture, adorable Shirley Temple
lives an emotional story that
will leave a choke in your
throat though your heart's
full of joy!

Our Lovable Little Shirley again.
She sings, dances, and creeps right
into your heart. See her in

Our Little Girl

with

ROSEMARY AMES
JOEL McCREA

SHIRLEY — You'll Make
The Whole World Happier!

"THE BEST 'SHIP' STORY YET
TO REACH THE SCREEN!"

EXCITEMENT
BLAZES!

LAUGHS
ABOUND!

As a luxurious transatlantic liner
speeds to port — the checkered
past and shifting fortunes of six
strange passengers tangle — and
their intrigues churn a baffling mys-
tery into raging adventure punctu-
ated with laughter.

Black Sheep

with

EDMUND LOWE
CLAIRE TREVOR

TOM BROWN
EUGENE PALLETTE
ADRIENNE AMES
HERBERT MUNDIN
FORD STERLING

It Tingles With Action!
—Flashes With Fun!

Two more Cartoons for the Children:

MICKEY MOUSE in
"DOG NAPPER"

— ALSO —
A TERRYTOON CARTOON,
"The Bull Fight"

CINESOUND REVIEW, ETC.

Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 7 February 1936

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Manager Tom Rees continued to show pictures at the theatre for the next 23 years until he retired in 1949. Tom and Ruby boarding at the Peterborough Hotel, lived there for 37 years.

Tom and Ruby retired to Adelaide where Tom died in March 1953 aged 74.

The Capitol Theatre was purchased by Mr Oskar Mathias Rondahl of Clare and was closed for several weeks while the premises were renovated inside and out. The theatre reopened on May 28th, 1949. The theatre was improved with a new sound speaker system and new perforated sound screen.

The theatre was leased to several operators over the next few decades until it was sold in 1973 to Ronald Wilsby. The Capitol Theatre closed its doors on 30 June 1976. The manager Mr Les Hucks opened the drive-in Theatre on the Yongala Road on 3 March 1978.

The theatre was taken over by second hand dealer Alan Trenwith in 1979 until 1982 when present owner Phil White took over the lease and then subsequently purchased the building.

The building is now known as '229 on Main' and is a very unique café.



CAPITOL THEATRE

Crowded House Greet Re-Opening

Peterborough now has a picture theatre of which we can be justly proud, and we offer sincere congratulations to the new proprietor, Mr. O. M. Rondahl, on the excellent way in which he has had the premises renovated. The color scheme of cream and blue is eye-arresting yet restful and the whole presents a very pleasant sight.

The most important improvement is the new sound equipment by Raycophone, installed by Harrington's Pty. Ltd., of Currie Street, Adelaide, which gave the crowded house on the re-opening night, last Saturday, the opportunity of seeing the feature clearly and hearing every shade and inflection of the voices and music of 'A Date with Judy.' The six young ladies in their uniforms seated the crowd efficiently and with little fuss and this was an added feature.

On Friday night, a few members of the community were invited to a preview and had the interesting and unique experience of seeing the first run of a new equipment. It was very enjoyable from every angle.

This week the matinee will start at 2 p.m. and the same programme will be shown as advertised for Saturday and Monday each week.

'Till the Clouds Roll By,' the surging, ringing tribute to Jerome Kern and his memorable music in rainbow technicolor is the main feature for the weekend and includes all the best singing stars—Judy Garland, Dinah Shore and Frank Sinatra. Supporting will be interesting shorts.

For Wednesday, a double feature programme is advertised. Dick Powell in "Cornered" and Wally Brown in "A Genius at Work."

Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 3 June 1949



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229 on Main Café
Photo – via Face Book



The Capitol Theatre has a double with an almost identical theatre built for the Waterside Workers Federation in Port Adelaide.

Construction of the W.M.A. (Working Man's Association) Theatre began on 5th December 1926 when the foundation stone was laid. It opened on Thursday 14th July 1927 and was built by local contractors Silver and Ollrich who had built the theatre in Peterborough earlier in 1926.

It was used as a picture theatre of the W.W.F. Union and their families before a damaging strike and limited availability of quality films shut it down and the hall was then used as a performance and meeting hall.

<https://capturetheatres.wixsite.com>



W.M.A. Theatre - 2026
Photo – Steve and Dianne Moffatt



Capitol Theatre - 1975
Photo - Lionel Noble Collection



Capitol Theatre - 2026